Meghalaya, the mesmerising hill state in India's scenic north-east, has completed 50 years of statehood in 2022. While geographical distance and barriers have often slowed down the progress of this state, since 2018, when Chief Minister Conrad K. Sangma-led government took charge of Meghalaya, it has witnessed unprecedented socio-economic development across all sectors.

Meghalaya, blessed with immense natural beauty and resources, is one of India's smallest states. With an area of 22,720 square kilometre, it's 22nd in terms of size among states and 24th in terms of population, as home to 3.8 million people. Yet, the north-eastern state, which shares international border with Bangladesh, is unique in many ways. With an average annual rainfall of 1,150 cm, Meghalaya, which literally means abode of cloud, receives the highest amount of rainfall in the country. Recognised as a state of Indian Union, it may be just 50-year-old, but in 2018, the International Commission on Stratigraphy, which has divided the Holocene epoch into three subdivisions, named the late Holocene as the Meghalayan age. A speleothem in Mawmluh cave, which indicates, a dramatic worldwide climate event around 2250 BCE, has been chosen as the boundary stratotype.

The year 2018 also saw another change in Meghalaya—Conrad K. Sangma, only 40-year-old then, took charge of the state. It was a baptism by fire for the son of former Lok Sabha speaker PA Sangma, the most illustrious political leader from the north-east. The state was reeling under economic distress, corruption, socio-political frictions, and a collective sense of despair. Armed with a management degree from the prestigious Imperial College in United Kingdom, Chief Minister Conrad Sangma hit the ground running and set his priorities—sector-specific policies for economic development and ensuring their speedy execution.

And it was not going to be a short-term mission. In the very beginning of his tenure, Chief Minister Conrad Sangma said that it was imperative to lay down the vision and roadmap to build the Meghalaya that people of the state would want to see in the next 50 years. "We have to envision a plan for the next 50 years and work accordingly to ensure that we have a progressive state with equal opportunities for our people when we celebrate 100 years of statehood," said the chief minister. As evident now, the focus was not just on growth, but on inclusive development where every citizen of Meghalaya has been part of the progress.

And for that to happen the state needed to identify the capability of individuals and engage them in areas of expertise to bring out efficiency and deliver maximum results. So Chief Minister Conrad Sangma created task forces for formulating policies on education, telecom, youth, and sports. The objective was to frame policies considering the concerns of all stakeholders. Several policies, including on industries and tourism, were revisited. Every area of growth was spotted and encouraged. The microscopic focus was evident from the beginning.

The chief minister firmly believes that education is the key to unlocking the growth potential of the state. That's the reason it has been given top priority. "If we are able to create the right policies and work in a committed manner towards achieving our goals, it may take time, but we will surely be able to demonstrate Meghalaya as a shining example of how education should be imparted to the youngsters," says the chief minister. His government has already demonstrated the model. In the India Today State of the States survey, Meghalaya has been adjudged the Most Improved Small State in Education for two consecutive years—2021 and 2022.

To fundamentally transform the agriculture sector, his government launched a scheme termed FOCUS (Farmers Collectivization for Upscaling Production and Marketing System). This flagship initiative for the state's producers envisages the bottom-up collectivization of producers into groups. The producer groups are provided an amount of Rs 5,000 per producer as a group corpus for increasing production and productivity. This programme is a firm step to empower the farmers of Meghalaya so that they can come together and solve their immediate problems. Within a year, the programme has been a grand success. It currently covers almost 20,000 producer groups comprising 2,70,000 families, 330 cooperative societies and about 100 aggregation and processing centres. Hundreds of success stories are emerging from the FOCUS program.

Taking inspiration from the success and demand of the FOCUS programme, CM Conrad Sangma's government then launched the FOCUS+ programme. Under this, an unconditional and untied annual cash benefit of Rs 5,000 is provided individual bank accounts of each farmer who is part of a producer group to take up any farm production-related activity. With the FOCUS and the FOCUS+ programmes, each rural household will receive a cash benefit of Rs 10,000 per annum.

> We are building a brand Meghalaya on which every citizen can capitalize and benefit. Together, we have taken significant strides in the development of the state through collaborative governance, decisive leadership, and determination.

Conrad K. Sangma
Chief Minister, Meghalaya